



DIVERSITY IN FASHION

In May 1966, the first African American model appeared on the cover of British *Vogue*. Her name was Donyale Luna and she challenged the biased portrayal of beauty as all-white. But change happened slowly. US *Vogue* had its first black cover girl, Beverly Johnson, in the August 1974 edition. In Britain the next black model on a *Vogue* cover was Gail O'Neill in 1986, followed by Naomi Campbell a year later. By that time, the African-born model Iman and Jamaican-born Grace Jones had become regulars in the pages of *Vogue* and on the catwalks for Yves Saint Laurent and Thierry Mugler. Other steps towards diversity included 70-year-old Daphne Selfe being cast to walk at London Fashion Week in 1998, and Alexander McQueen casting amputee Aimee Mullins in his show for Spring/Summer 1999.

More recently, Kelly Knox, who was born missing a left forearm, modelled for Teatum Jones in the opening show of London Fashion Week and fronted a campaign for Primark, while curve model Ashley Graham has appeared on the cover of *Vogue* and walked for top labels including Michael Kors and Dolce & Gabbana. In 2016, transgender model Hari Nef walked the runway for Gucci, and was given control of the brand's Snapchat for fashion week. Models on social media have changed the business of casting: as they connect directly with the public and give them influence, agents and editors are no longer making isolated decisions. With 4.2 million Instagram followers Winnie Harlow, who as she herself says "happens to have vitiligo", which creates contrasting coloration of her skin, is proof that the fashion-buying public supports models who celebrate their differences. And at the 2016 Vetements and Balenciaga shows, the audience immediately criticized the use of all-white models by posting their negative comments on social media. Gradually, the fashion industry has realized that the consumers who buy clothes and accessories want to see models who reflect the diversity of the world we live in.

“

All our differences are part of who we are, but they don't define us.

WINNIE HARLOW, MODEL, 2018

”

◀ RUNWAY REGULAR

Since her 2014 debut at London Fashion Week, Winnie Harlow has appeared on numerous runways. Here she walks for Julien MacDonald in 2019.